channels were in frenetic competition. At CNN-IBN, we genuinely believed we had assembled what we liked to call ‘the best team in politics’.

There was Swapan Dasgupta as the premier right-wing voice and someone who had an inside track to Modi; the liberal historian and public intellectual Ramachandra Guha was among the rare breed who spoke as well as he wrote; Manini Chatterjee of the *Telegraph* offered a punchy counterpoint to Swapan’s Modinama; P. Sainath, a Magsaysay award-winning journalist, had documented rural India better than anyone else; Kumar Ketkar offered a robust old-style Nehruvian perspective; and just in case the right wing felt outgunned, we had the straight-talking political economist, Surjit Bhalla, who I would often term as being ‘on the right of Atilla the Hun!’ Our number crunching was done by Prof. Karandikar while the political inputs were handled by Dr Sandeep Shastri of the Lokniti team, whose enthusiasm would usually lift my spirits. The only member of our original election panel we were missing that morning was Prof. Dipankar Gupta, the leading political sociologist who had the great skill of making his point forcefully without raising his voice.

The panel had come prepared to stay in the studio for several hours. ‘Don’t worry, we have lots of food and drink organized to keep you going,’ I assured them. In the end, it was all over in the first three hours. The first round of leads that come on a television programme are usually from postal ballots, so one can be easily misled by the initial numbers. But within half an hour of the counting having started, a clear trend had begun to emerge.

The BJP was well ahead in most seats in north and west India from where leads were now coming thick and fast. At around 9 a.m., we had a flash saying Rahul was trailing. My first instinctive response was—could Smriti Irani be the Raj Narain of 2014 (the socialist leader had defeated Indira Gandhi in Rae Bareli in 1977)? Then, we had another news flash—Supriya Sule, Sharad Pawar’s daughter, was trailing in Baramati. Surely not, I muttered to myself, the Pawars had been winning the seat for four decades now. From Thiruvananthapuram came the news that Shashi Tharoor was also lagging behind. Would the BJP actually break its duck in Kerala?